welcomed on shore by a flute-playing Jewish girl. He made many converts, so there are Indians today whose ancestors were Christian well before any European discovered Christianity (and before the forebears of many of today's Hindu chauvinists were even conscious of themselves as Hindus). One of the oldest mosques in the world outside the Arabian peninsula is also in Kerala, in Kodungalloor. The India where the muezzin's prayer and the pujari's mantra co-exist is an India of which we can all be proud.

But, as we know, there is also the India in which murderous mobs in Odisha sought to kill Christians and destroy their places of worship and homes, pulled down the Babri Masjid, conducted the pogrom in Gujarat and lynched Mohammed Akhlaq and Pehlu Khan more recently.

Tragically, the cycle of violence goes on, spawning new hostages to history, ensuring that future generations will be taught new wrongs to set right. We live, Octavio Paz once wrote, between oblivion and memory. Memory and oblivion: how one leads to the other, and back again, has been the concern of much of my writing. Today we are facing people who wish to wipe out memory, and supplant it with new 'memories' of their own invention. As I pointed out in the last words of my novel *Riot*, history is not a web woven with innocent hands.

But as this book is about Hinduism, what sticks in my craw is the claim of the perpetrators of such violence that they are acting in defence of my faith. Hinduism believes that there are various ways of reaching the ultimate truth. To me, the fact that adherents of this faith, in a particular perversion of its tenets, have chosen to take human life and destroy somebody else's sacred place in its name, to kill others because of the absence of a foreskin or lack of a mark on the forehead, this ultimately makes me, as a Hindu, deeply sorrowful and, in a very fundamental way, ashamed.

As I have shown throughout this book, how, after all, can such a religion lend itself to 'fundamentalism'? That devotees of this supremely tolerant faith have assaulted Muslims and Christians in its name is particularly galling. As we have seen, Hinduism has survived the Aryans, the Mughals, the British; it has taken from each—language, art, food, learning—and outlasted them all. Muslim invaders destroyed